Bajaj asked, ‘We would like to know what you believe in, what you stand for, because leadership is important.’

Modi listened to the rush of criticism and then hit back. ‘You and your pseudo-secular friends can come to Gujarat if you want an answer. Talk to my people. Gujarat is the most peaceful state in the country.’

Modi was now seething. He carried this sense of hurt and anger back with him to Gujarat; this rage would become a driving force channelized towards greater self-reinvention, towards revenge on those who questioned him critically. *‘Een Dilliwalon ko Gujarat kya hai yeh dikhana padega’* (We have to show these Dilliwallas what Gujarat is), he told one of his trusted aides. Within days, a group of Gujarati businessmen led by Gautam Adani established a rival business organization—the Resurgent Group of Gujarat—and called on the CII’s Gujarat chapter to resign for ‘failing to protect the interests of the state’. The CII was on the verge of a split, forcing its director general Tarun Das to broker peace through senior BJP leader Arun Jaitley. Das was forced to personally deliver a letter of apology to Modi. ‘We, in the CII, are very sorry for the hurt and pain you have felt, and I regret very much the misunderstanding that has developed.’ Modi had shown corporate India who was the boss.

That year, the Gujarat government launched its Vibrant Gujarat summit, designed to showcase the state as an investment destination and re-emphasize the traditional Gujarati credo—‘Gujarat’s business is business’. I attended the summit in 2005 and was struck by the precision with which the event was organized. This was not just another government initiative—it was a glitzy event where one individual towered over all else. Every speaker would begin their speech by praising the chief minister, some a shade more effusively than others—Anil Ambani of Reliance Communications even going to the extent of likening Modi to Mahatma Gandhi and describing him as a ‘king of kings’.

While corporate India fell in line, the media was proving more recalcitrant. On 12 October 2007, a few weeks before the Gujarat assembly elections, I had the occasion to moderate a session with Modi at the *Hindustan Times* Leadership Summit. Dressed, appropriately perhaps, in a